

Case Rubric

2026-03-20

- **Course:** Management Information Systems (MIS)
- **Instructor:** Suresh L. Paul

Overview

This document tells you exactly what is expected of you for both the **written report** and the **presentation** including how every point will be awarded. Read it carefully as a team to discuss strategy and division of labor before you begin your case.

Remember, we are not summarizing the case – we are analyzing the case. While facts of the case needs to be summarized, they are not the end game. Your job is to think like a management information system consultant who has been handed a real crisis and asked: *What happened, why did it happen, what did it cost, and what should never happen again?*

Deliverables at a Glance

Deliverable	Length	Format Options	Weight	Overall Weight
Written Report	5–10 double-sided pages	Word (.docx), PDF, Markdown, LaTeX, Canva	33% of case grade	10% of course grade
Presentation	10–30 slides	PowerPoint (.pptx), PDF, Quarto, LaTeX, Canva	67% of case grade	20% of course grade

Team Appendix Required: Attach a detailed contribution log to the written report listing each team member’s specific contributions (sections written, research conducted, visuals created). Every member must be prepared to answer questions on any part of the case during the presentation.

AI Writing Policy: AI tools may **not** be used to generate written content for the report. Use Google Docs with version history enabled for collaborative drafting; share the version history link upon request.

Required Structure — Written Report

Your report must address the following **six sections in order**. Each section maps to a graded criterion (see rubric below). Do not skip or merge sections as it will make it harder to grade and assign points.

Section 1 — Company Profile & Competitive Context

Before analyzing the incident, you must understand the company.

Answer all of the following:

- **What does this company do?** Describe its core business in plain language.
- **Brief history:** When was it founded? What milestones shaped its current form?

- History: Since when has this company been in existence. Which industry did it first serve? Who was the founding member(s)?
- Who is the current CEO (or the present leadership team)? Are they still operating in the same business?
- **Industry context:** What industry or industries does it operate in? Who are its main competitors?
- **How does it make money?** Identify its primary revenue streams.
 - Geography: Does the company only operate within the U.S.?
 - History: Revenue trends and projections.
- **Who are its customers and clients?** B2B, B2C, government, or a mix? Give specifics.
 - How crucial is it to each of those clients and customers that information system is secure and working as intended?
- **What is its competitive moat?**
 - Why do customers choose this company over alternatives? (e.g., switching costs, network effects, proprietary technology, brand, regulatory license)
 - What effect do you suppose this moat have on pricing strategies?
- **IT/technology posture:** How central is information technology to this company's operations? What is known or estimable about its IT budget, infrastructure scale, or technology dependency? (Use public disclosures, SEC filings, analyst reports, or credible estimates.)

Note: A student who cannot describe what a company does and how it earns money is not ready to *analyze* what went wrong with it.

Section 2 — Information Systems Environment

Map the technology landscape before the incident.

- **Core information systems in use:** What types of systems does this company rely on (ERP, CRM, POS, cloud infrastructure, AI/ML systems, security platforms, etc.)? For example, in the Equifax and the Capital One case study analyzed in class, the customer financial data parked in the cloud infrastructure was compromised because of a security platform vulnerability – a patch fix even though available was not rendered, deployed, and detected for a long time; facilitating the breach.
- **System interdependencies:** How do these systems connect to one another? Where are the critical integration points? This may help you analyze whether a failure in one system has cascading effects on other systems in your organization. In fact, mapping system interdependencies is a vital diagnostic tool to find out how failures happened in technology-related events.
- **Third-party and vendor dependencies:** What external software, cloud providers, or service vendors does the company rely on? How critical are these to operations?
- **Points of failure — pre-incident:** Before the incident occurred, what vulnerabilities or architectural weaknesses were present in the system? (Identify at least three based on case evidence and external research.)
- **Data and privacy considerations:** What sensitive data does this company handle? What regulatory obligations apply (HIPAA, PCI-DSS, GDPR, etc.)?

Note: Use a simple systems diagram or table to illustrate interdependencies if it adds clarity.

Section 3 — Incident Analysis

This is the core analytical section. Be precise and evidence-based. Avoid opinions.

Answer all of the following, organized as sub-sections:

3a. What Happened? Provide a clear, factual chronological account of the incident. Include a timeline if helpful. Distinguish between what is confirmed and what is alleged or estimated.

3b. When Did It Happen? Specify key dates and durations. How long did the disruption last? Was there a lag between cause and detection?

3c. Why Did It Happen? Identify the **root cause(s)** — not just the proximate trigger. Apply at least two MIS frameworks or concepts from class (e.g., change management failure, single point of failure, technical debt, social engineering, production gap, AI hallucination). Distinguish between technical failures, process failures, and human failures.

3d. Who Is Responsible? Assign responsibility at multiple levels: individual decision-makers, teams, the organization as a whole, and (where applicable) third-party vendors. Avoid vague blame — name roles and decisions specifically.

3e. Could It Have Been Prevented? Identify the **key human decision point** — the single moment where a different choice would most likely have prevented or significantly reduced the harm. What should have been done? By whom? When?

3f. Damages and Impact Quantify and categorize the harm across all stakeholder groups:

Stakeholder	Type of Harm	Estimated Magnitude
The firm itself	Financial, operational, legal	\$ figures where available
Customers/users	Service disruption, data exposure, financial loss	Describe scope
Shareholders/investors	Stock price impact, market cap loss	Where applicable
Employees	Job losses, morale, legal exposure	Where applicable
General public / society	Systemic risk, trust in technology	Qualitative assessment
Regulators / government	Investigations, fines, legislative response	Where applicable

Also assess **reputational damage**: How was public perception of the company affected? What was the media narrative? Did it change customer or partner behavior?

Note: Link and professionally cite (APA style) cases analyzed in class. For example, was the dollar damages more or less than the damages faced by the Target after the public learned about their pregnancy prediction model?

Section 4 — Broader MIS Implications

Zoom out from the specific incident.

- **Implications for IT infrastructure design:** What does this case teach us about how IT systems should — or should not — be built and maintained?
- **Implications for cloud computing:** If the incident involves cloud-dependent systems, what risks does this expose about cloud adoption strategies?
- **Implications for AI systems:** If AI played a role (or if AI adoption could have changed outcomes), what governance questions does this raise?
- **Could this happen today?** Given the current technological environment (as of your writing date), would the same incident be more or less likely? More or less damaging? Explain your reasoning.
- **Cross-case connections:** Do the failures in this case resemble patterns from other cases discussed in class? What insight does comparison offer? Link and professionally cite (APA style) cases analyzed in class.

Section 5 — Recommendations

Be specific and actionable. Generic advice will not earn full marks.

Provide **five concrete, prioritized recommendations** — three immediate (0–6 months) and two long-term (6 months–3 years). For each:

- State the recommendation clearly. Is there any historical precedence why this recommendation will work?
- Explain the MIS rationale (what failure mode does it address?).
- Identify who in the organization is responsible for implementing it.
- Note any trade-offs or costs.

Section 6 — Key Lessons

Distill your analysis into takeaways with transferable value.

Each case discussed in class offers lessons in the end. Study them. In a much similar way, identify and explain **five key lessons** from your case. These should be lessons with relevance beyond this one company that you can generalize: applicable to other organizations, in similar industries, or technology contexts. Each lesson should be:

- Stated as a clear, actionable principle (not a vague platitude)
- Grounded in specific evidence from the case
- Connected to an MIS concept or framework

Required Structure — Presentation

Your presentation must be structured to tell a compelling story, not just report information. The suggested flow is:

1. **Hook** — Open with the most dramatic or counterintuitive fact from the case (1–2 slides)
2. **Company & Systems Overview** — Who they are; how technology is central to their operations (2–3 slides)
3. **The Incident** — What happened, timeline, key decisions (3–5 slides)
4. **Root Cause Analysis** — Why it happened; MIS framework application (2–3 slides)
5. **Damage Assessment** — Quantified impact across stakeholders; visuals required (2–3 slides)
6. **Broader Implications** — What this means for IT, cloud, and AI (2–3 slides)
7. **Recommendations** — Specific, prioritized, actionable (2–3 slides)
8. **Key Lessons** — Transferable principles (1–2 slides)
9. **Q&A Prompt Slide** — Pose one provocative question to the audience (1 slide)

Note: **Visual requirement:** Your presentation must include at least one original chart, diagram, or infographic — not copied from the case reading. Options include: timeline of events, systems architecture diagram, stakeholder impact matrix, cost breakdown chart, or before/after comparison table.